

Research Project: Franciscan Eco-Theology and Environmental Attitudes

A term paper submitted for the
RM in Management and Applied Microeconomics

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January 29, 2026

Abstract

Our project focuses on the effect of exposure to the main Mendicant orders of the 12th and 15th century - the Franciscan and Dominican - on the contemporary environmental attitudes. We find that that higher Franciscan is associated with less pro-environmental attitudes, while higher Dominican exposure is associated with more pro-environmental attitudes.

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1 Introduction

2 Context and Hypotheses

We will first explore the historical context of the two main Mendicant orders - the Franciscan and the Dominican - to formulate our hypothesis on how those theological beliefs influenced the environmental attitudes.

2.1 The Franciscan Order

The Franciscan Order was founded in the early 13th century by St. Francis of Assisi (1181-1226), who was recognized by the Catholic Church as the patron saint of ecology, widely known for his profound affection towards nature and animals. In his "Canticles of the Creatures," St. Francis refers to the sun and the moon as brother and sister. Thus, the Franciscan Order emphasized the imitation of Christ through the ideals of poverty and humility. They focus on collective life, communal care, antimaterialism, shame, compassion, simplicity, and humbleness (Arrunada and Lopez-Manuel, 2024).

2.2 The Dominican Order

In contrast, the Dominican Order, founded by St. Dominic (1170-1221) in the early 13th century, prioritized intellectual and educational mission of medieval Catholic Church. They founded and staffed universities and produced extensive theological and practical writings (Le Goff, 1980; Boyle 1981). The Dominicans emphasized the importance of critical thinking, self-examination, and moral development (Hinnebusch 1966; Lesnick 1989).

2.3 Hypothesis

Because of the strong association of the Franciscan Order with nature and animals, we would naturally expect more-environmental attitudes in regions with stronger Franciscan exposure. Therefore, we initially hypothesized that higher historical exposure to the Franciscan Order would be associated with more pro-environmental attitudes, while higher historical exposure to the Dominican Order would be associated with less pro-environmental attitudes. However, our results state the opposite.

3 Literature Review

A similar study was conducted by Arruñada and López-Manuel (2024), who examined the effects of the two main Mendicant orders of the Late Middle Ages - the Dominican and the Franciscan. Through their emphasis on guilt, shame, compassion, and analytical thinking, these orders shape outcomes at the cognitive, interpersonal, and institutional levels, which together constitute the “foundations” of impersonal exchange. They further argue that eco-theological beliefs can foster distinct values and cultural norms. For example, at the interpersonal level, “Dominicans promoted guilt as a driver of prosocial behavior toward strangers”, fostering a culture of individual accountability and independence, “whereas Franciscans encouraged compassion and shame, which strengthened bonds within the group” (Arruñada and López-Manuel, 2024). Consistent with these differences, the authors document contrasting effects of Dominican and Franciscan influence on impersonal exchange. Thus, their findings supports our results for distinct effects of the two orders on environmental attitudes.

Our study also relates to the broader literature on the role of Medieval Churches and persistence of cultural norms. The Church, as an institution, played a pervasive role in every aspect of life in medieval Europe, shaping people’s lives, values, and behavior throughout the Middle Ages (Lynch, 2024). Once a religious institution becomes established, the values and norms it historically imposes tend to persist, as such cultural legacies “leave an imprint on values that endures” over time (Inglehart and Baker, 2000). Although religious institutions have lost some of the formal allegiance of their followers in modern societies, Inglehart and Baker’s findings suggest that religiously rooted value orientations continue to influence individuals, as these values become embedded in national cultures and are transmitted through educational institutions and mass media, allowing religiously rooted value orientations to persist at the individual level.

Another important strand of literature relates to the determinants of environmental attitudes. In many literatures it was examined that cultural differences might influence environmental attitudes (Chwialkowska et al., 2020; Khan et al., 2024; Yang et al., 2024; Tam, 2025). Some theoretical models argue that pro-environmental attitudes may be rooted in self-interest and utility maximization. In particular, a longer life expectancy may increase individuals’ willingness to support environmental efforts to fight climate change (Mariani et al., 2010). Additionally, importantly for our research, many other literature with similar research interests commonly measure the environmental attitudes using the survey datasets (EVS) (Gelissen, 2007; Behler, 2025).

Our research is the first to examine the effect of exposure to the two main Mendicant orders of the Medieval Ages - the Franciscan and the Dominican - on contemporary environmental attitudes.

4 Data and Methodology

4.1 Exposure Measure

4.2 Environmental Attitudes Measure

5 Results

6 Limitations and Further Research

7 Conclusion

8 References